

REPERTOIRE TRENDS

What 664 Performances Reveal About Choral Programming in 2025–26

A first look at repertoire trends from a season of logged concert programs

By Rick Retzko

Every fall, choral directors make hundreds of small decisions — what to open the winter concert with, which arranger’s “Auld Lang Syne” arrangement to use, whether this is finally the year to program that Ešenvalds octavo sitting in the folder. Multiply those decisions across even a few dozen programs and patterns start to emerge: which composers are actually being sung right now, not just anthologized; which arrangers quietly dominate a season without anyone naming them “trending”; and whether the field is moving in a direction any one director might not notice from inside their own program.

This article is a first attempt to look at those patterns directly, using data from ChoirTrends, a platform where directors log their concert programs — repertoire, ensembles, dates, and schools — as they build each season. Over the 2025–26 school year (September 2025 through July 2026), directors logged 57 concert programs from 37 schools, totaling 664 individual performances of 631 unique titles.

A note on the data, up front. This is a small, self-selected sample — early users of one platform, concentrated in New Jersey (33 of 57 programs), with smaller representation from Rhode Island, New York, Pennsylvania, Wisconsin, Maryland, and Tennessee, plus a first international data point from a school in Trier, Germany. It is not a scientific survey of American choral programming. What it offers instead is a real, unfiltered look at actual concert programs as directors built them — no anthologizing, no self-reporting bias toward “important” repertoire, just what got performed. As the dataset grows in future seasons, we expect these patterns

METHODOLOGY

Data drawn from ChoirTrends concert program logs, September 1, 2025–July 31, 2026. Figures include only performances with a matching program and event date in range; composer/arranger figures require an attributed composer or arranger on the song title record. “Trend” threshold set at 3+ performances per the platform’s standard reporting convention. Full query detail available on request.

to sharpen; for now, treat what follows as a signal worth watching rather than a settled conclusion.

Living composers, not historical ones, dominate the season. Outside the December repertoire, the most-programmed composers were overwhelmingly working composers: Elaine Hagenberg, Jennifer Lucy Cook, Ola Gjeilo, and Kyle Pederson each appeared in the season's top tier, all writing music from within the last decade. The one historical name to break into the top five — George Frideric Handel — owed his position almost entirely to holiday programming; strip out December, and the top of the list is entirely contemporary. This tracks with a broader shift many directors have felt anecdotally: that today's active repertoire pipeline is increasingly built around living voices, not the historical canon, except where the calendar itself calls for tradition.

A distinct Nordic/Baltic sound runs through the season. One of the clearest stylistic threads in the data is a cluster of composers writing spacious, atmospheric, text-centered choral music from the Nordic and Baltic countries: Ola Gjeilo (Norway), Pärt Uusberg (Estonia), and Eriks Ešenvalds (Latvia). Gjeilo alone was performed 7 times across 6 different programs — more than any composer except Traditional/anonymous settings — with “Tundra” and “Northern Lights” each appearing twice. Uusberg and Ešenvalds each appeared 3 times across 3 programs, clearing the “trend” threshold on a much smaller total sample size than Gjeilo. Taken together, this Nordic/Baltic aesthetic was present in roughly one in ten logged programs — notable given that none of these composers write primarily in English or draw on American choral tradition. It's a pattern consistent with what several state ACDA reading sessions have highlighted in recent years, and this data suggests it's translating into actual programming, not just conference buzz.

One piece stood out above the rest. “Time,” by Jennifer Lucy Cook, was the most-performed single title in the dataset — 6 performances, entirely concentrated in the spring semester. No other title came close during spring; the next tier (“Glow” by Eric Whitacre, “Veni, Veni Emmanuel” by Michael John Trotta, and “Muusika” by Pärt Uusberg) each landed 3 performances across the full year. What's more striking than any single title, though, is how rare repeats were at all: of 664 total performances, only 33 involved a title performed more than once anywhere in the dataset. Directors, at least in this sample, are not reaching for the same shelf.

Winter and spring tell different stories. Splitting the season in two reveals a clear seasonal divide. Winter programming (September through January, 22 concerts) leaned sacred and seasonal — Handel, Byrd, Victoria, and Vivaldi appeared alongside Gjeilo's wintry soundscapes and Trotta's “Veni, Veni Emmanuel.” On the arranging side, Roger Emerson was the dominant voice of the winter season by a wide margin: 10 performances across 7 programs,

nearly double the next most-used arranger. Spring programming (February through July, 35 concerts) shifted decisively toward contemporary American voices — Cook, Hagenberg, Pederson, Rollo Dilworth, and Marta Keen led the composer list, while the arranger landscape broadened considerably, with Mark Brymer, Kirby Shaw, Craig Hella Johnson, and Audrey Snyder all posting strong numbers. Pop crossover repertoire also surfaced in spring specifically — arrangements of “Dust in the Wind” and “Homeward Bound” appeared multiple times, suggesting some directors are deliberately bridging choral and popular repertoire for spring audiences in a way that doesn’t show up in winter programming at all.

What we don’t yet know. Ensemble-level detail — whether a piece was sung by an SATB choir, a treble ensemble, a TTBB group, or performed a cappella — was only reliably recorded for about 18% of performances in this dataset; the rest are logged simply as “Unknown” ensemble type. Where we do have that detail, some patterns emerge (SATB choirs accounted for the largest typed share, and a cappella performances were concentrated there as well), but with this much missing data, we’re not treating the ensemble-type breakdown as reliable yet — it’s included for context, not as a finding.

Where this goes next. This is a first snapshot from a single season and a still-small, geographically concentrated dataset. The value of this kind of analysis compounds with scale: as more directors log more seasons, patterns like the Nordic/Baltic thread, the winter/spring arranger divide, and shifts in the historical-versus-contemporary balance will become sharper and more defensible. We’d welcome the chance to revisit this analysis in a future issue with a larger, more geographically diverse sample — and we’d welcome any director’s data as part of that picture.

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ChoirTrends.com is a free resource offered as my gift to the choral community, requiring only the commitment to upload at least two choral programs per year.

TheDirectorsRoom.com helps directors run auditioned regional and state honors choirs, handling registration and adjudication so the focus can stay on the music.